

too dark, or vice-versa. While there are a few cameras that allow native support for HDR photography, this is beyond the scope of most amateurs. This section discusses how to artificially produce HDR photographs, using an image editor and any digital camera.

The first question to put out of the way is where HDR should be used. Practically, all photos taken during harsh lighting conditions, either too much or too little light comes under the purview of HDR. Landscapes during sunsets or sunrise, indoor shots with a harsh afternoon sun streaming through an open window, and buildings at dusk or dawn all look better with HDR. Take a photo of the same subject under a high exposure setting and a low exposure setting. You will see a few details stand out in the first photo, and totally different details emerge in the next photo. An artificial HDR photo will combine the extremes, bringing out all the possible details in a real-world like image. Although they replicate real world colours, many HDR photos look artificial because of the way they are manipulated, and their colours being counter-intuitive to everyday experience with photos.

Taking multiple images of the same subject with different camera settings is known as bracketing. Some DSLRs come with a bracketing feature, that lets you take multiple photos in different settings automatically. Bracketing can be used with attributes other than exposure, like focus or aperture settings. However, most consumer digital cameras do not have a bracketing facility, so you will have to do this on your own. Three images in low, medium and high exposure settings is a bare minimum for producing an HDR image. If you want to be absolutely sure of capturing the entire range of natural luminosity in a subject, take upto six or eight different photographs on different exposure settings as permitted by the camera.

Photoshop has a feature that lets you combine bracketed photographs into an HDR image. Another way to create HDR photos is to bring out the details and the dynamic range with an image editing software. The idea is to digitally compensate for the exposure and then merge the areas with different exposures.

In this photo for example, details in the sky and the shadows under the bridge have been preserved because the